

Background and Founding Rationale

An independent, non-profit foundation dedicated to the long-term preservation of contemporary artistic documentation. Updated August 2026.

1. The fragility of artistic documentation

Throughout history, artists have created works that shape how societies understand themselves and their time. Yet the documentation surrounding artistic creation — the images, records, catalogues, exhibition histories, and personal archives that accompany artworks — has always been fragile and easily lost.

In earlier centuries this documentation existed in physical form: letters, archives, catalogues, and museum records. These materials were preserved, however imperfectly, within libraries, museums, and other institutional collections.

Today the situation has changed. The documentation of contemporary art increasingly exists in digital form, dispersed across private databases, gallery systems, personal websites, and commercial platforms. While these systems make information readily accessible in the present, they are unstable over time. When galleries close, digital services disappear, or artists lose access to platforms, the documentation surrounding artworks vanishes with them.

What is lost is not only information about individual works. Entire histories of artistic production — exhibitions, installations, critical texts, and archival materials — become fragmented or disappear. For artists, this weakens the continuity of their own practice. For collectors, it creates uncertainty around provenance and authenticity. For researchers and historians, it leaves gaps in the cultural record of our time.

Despite the importance of this documentation, there is still no widely adopted, independent global infrastructure designed specifically to preserve the documentation of contemporary artists and their work.

2. The foundation

The Global Artist Registry Foundation (GARF) is an independent, non-profit foundation — a stichting registered under Dutch law in The Hague — created to address this challenge. It is independent in governance and purpose: not owned or controlled by commercial interests, and established solely to serve this cultural mission.

The foundation seeks to establish a long-term digital infrastructure through which artists themselves can document their work, exhibitions, and professional histories in a system

designed for permanence and accessibility. Within this framework, artists authenticate documentation relating to their own work. By combining artist-authenticated documentation, open standards, and long-term preservation strategies, GARF aims to create a durable, globally accessible record of contemporary artistic production — available to artists worldwide and usable across borders by institutions, researchers, collectors, and the public.

At the centre of this effort is the belief that artists should have the ability not only to preserve the record of their own work, but also to contribute directly to the cultural memory of their time.

3. What the registry provides

The registry today provides:

- Artist archives — archival-grade artwork records with structured metadata, dimensions, editions, media, provenance, condition, and images, each work carrying a permanent identifier.
- Exhibition and publication history — exhibitions, installation views, catalogues and page references, and professional CVs kept in sync with the artwork record.
- Verified identity — government-approved ID verification for artists and collectors, so that authorship of the record is established and traceable.
- Collection management — collectors and estates document holdings, valuations, physical locations, loans, and insurance documentation, with controlled professional access.
- Registrar registry — a vetted public directory of professional registrars whom artists, estates, and collectors can engage for cataloguing work.
- Catalogues raisonnés — a scholarly directory, named authors and committees, and a structured submission and review workflow, developed through the Catalogue Raisonné Foundation as a sister initiative.
- Preservation architecture — redundant archival storage, structured exports, and open data standards intended to survive any single platform, service, or generation of technology.

4. A shared responsibility: the GARF Global Alliance

Preserving artistic documentation is a shared responsibility. Museums, archives, galleries, collectors, registrars, and researchers all depend on reliable records of artistic production. No single organisation can hold that record alone, and none should.

For this reason the foundation is establishing the GARF Global Alliance — a collaborative framework bringing together artists, galleries, curators, registrars, museums, universities, corporate collections, and foundations around a shared standard for documenting and preserving contemporary art.

Members of the Alliance contribute in the way their practice allows:

- Artists and estates — authenticate and maintain the documentation of their own work.
- Galleries — transfer and align artwork records with the artists they represent.
- Curators — contribute exhibition histories, installation views, and critical texts.
- Registrars — provide professional cataloguing through the vetted public directory.
- Museums and archives — align institutional records and long-term preservation practice.
- Universities and researchers — use and strengthen the record as a scholarly resource.
- Corporate collections and foundations — document holdings and support the preservation mission.

The Alliance is open, non-commercial, and standards-based, and seeks alignment with international norms for cultural documentation and digital preservation. Organisations wishing to join as founding members are invited to contact the foundation.

5. Governance and funding

GARF is governed by a board and advised by professionals from the fields of collections management, art history, and archival practice. It has no commercial owners and distributes no profit. Its activities are funded by donations, supporting members, institutional partnerships, and grants.

Registered as a stichting under Dutch law. KvK 42024490. Jan Pieterszoon Coenstraat 7, 2595 WP 's-Gravenhage, The Hague, The Netherlands.

6. Conclusion

The Global Artist Registry Foundation represents more than a technological platform. It is an effort to build enduring cultural infrastructure: an independent, collaborative framework through which artists and institutions can help preserve the record of contemporary artistic production in our time.

Through this effort, the documentation of contemporary artistic creation can remain accessible not only to our own generation, but also to those who will study, interpret, and care for the art of our time in the future.